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Global Markets Research
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Global Memory

EQUITY: MEMORY

US mid-term election impact: options for big tech and memory

Quick Note

Federal AIDC moratorium unlikely, but "temporary pause" at state-level possible

We believe that mainstream Democrats are not opposed to AI itself. The key questions, in our view, are who pays for power, who provides oversight, how semiconductor chips are supplied to China, and how export controls on chipmaking equipment would evolve. A federal data center moratorium looks unlikely given divisions within the party and the presidential veto, and any brakes should come at the state level. In Texas and Georgia, candidates who campaigned on a "temporary pause" (halting new permits for AI data centres until rules are in place) won, while in Ohio both parties' candidates backed conditional approval. No governor-elect in major data center states have pledged a permanent ban; permanent bans exist only in some local ballot measures.

Impact on 2027F new capacity is limited; 2028F and beyond new capacity at risk of delay

The capacity coming online in 2027 is largely under construction already, so the impact should be limited, in our view. However, projects slated for 2028 and beyond are still in the planning stage and face the risk of delayed commissioning. Many of OpenAI's (unlisted) Stargate sites due for completion in 2028 are in states where candidates supporting a temporary pause won. With roughly six months left before construction must start for 2028 commissioning, any delay could push some 2028 capacity into 2029F. We estimate the delay-exposed size at about 7% of global new capacity in 2028F (~11% in our bear case).

Big tech companies likely to respond through self-funded power, higher utilization, and relocation; cumulative demand to remain intact, but cost per GW likely to rise

Big tech companies are already addressing regulatory concerns through community engagement and by bearing power costs itself. In March, Google (GOOGL US, Not rated), Microsoft (MSFT US, Not rated), Meta (META US, Not rated), Amazon (AMZN US, Not rated), OpenAI and others joined a pledge to build or buy their own power generation and cover grid upgrade costs, and some have begun dropping non-disclosure agreements. Given the strength of underlying data center demand, big tech companies are likely to minimize the impact by raising utilization at existing data centers, replacing GPUs, securing already-permitted sites, compensating local communities, and shifting capacity to friendlier states and overseas. Because the impacts are mainly relocation and delay rather than cancellation, cumulative demand should be preserved, although cost per GW is likely to rise due to community compensation and higher power cost burdens.

The fact that data centers are a core resource in the AI race with China should limit how long any temporary pause can last. The key question is whether pauses extend beyond a year or settle into higher power cost sharing and stricter permitting conditions; our base case is the latter. An uncertainty discount could weigh on share prices until the Texas legislative session ends in May 2027, with leveraged companies that have large Texas exposure being at the greatest risk.

(Continue on the next page)

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AIDC buildout delay to result in higher GPU rental price; memory market impact in 2028F and beyond is unlikely to be severe

On the other hand, delays in data center build-outs add upward pressure to cloud GPU rental prices, which are already rising. Higher compute rental prices could bring forward replacement with higher-performance GPUs, which might even be positive for semiconductor demand. In our view, the elections risks are relocation and some delays rather than cancellations. Considering big tech companies' various responses and memory makers' long-term supply agreements (LTAs), the impact on the memory market from 2028F onward is likely to be milder than the market fears. Even if some data center projects are delayed, we believe memory makers can preemptively adjust supply in 2+ years later through LTAs, limiting the risk of severe oversupply.

Big tech companies' possible responses

Below are possible responses to the mid-term election results that could be taken by big tech companies. In our view, measures 1, 2, 6, and 10 account for most of the offsets achievable in 2028F. Relocation (measures 4 and 5) should mainly take effect from 2029F, we believe.

Fig. 1: Big tech companies' possible responses to AIDC regulations

No.	Response	What it involves	Effect	Lead time	Offset within 2028
1	**Raise utilization of existing DCs**	- Fill unused space and raise rack density	Same GW, more compute	Months	High
2	**Bring projects under construction in line with new rules**	- Share grid costs - Disclose water usage	Minimizes delay, higher cost	Months	Medium
3	**Community negotation / compensation**	- Community benefit agreements - Bearing power costs - Ending NDAs	Higher approval odds, higher cost	6-12 mo	Medium
4	**Accelerate in less-regulated regions**	- Louisiana, Tennessee, Mississippi, Wyoming, Arizona, Pennsylvania, and federal land	Relocates capacity	12-24 mo	Low-Medium (power equipment bottlenecks)
5	**Accelerate overseas buildouts**	- Gulf, Northern Europe, India, Southeast Asia	Relocates/adds capacity	18-24 mo	Low (geopolitics / chip export approvals)
6	**Faster GPU replacement**	- Swap older GPUs for new ones in existing sites - Limits are early write-offs, rack power, and cooling	More compute on the same power; no new permits	Months	High
7	**Flexible-load commitments**	- Curtail use at peak demand - Texas law allows curtailing lrage loads in emergencies - Limit is increased difficulty of inferences	Eases grid concerns; faster interconnection	Months	Medium
8	**Water-saving design**	- Closed-loop cooling (already used at many Stargate sites) - Limit is slightly higher power usage	Removes water objections	Design stage	Medium
9	**Reuse existing industrial sites**	- Convert retied power plants, factories, and warehouses - Limit is that there are few suitable sites	Avoids farmland and rezoning disputes	6-18 mo	Medium
10	**Secure already-permitted capacity**	- Lease or acquire developer sites that already has permits and grid connections - Limit is premium pricing	Immediate capacity	Months	High
11	**Split into smaller sites**	- Stay below MW thresholds in some moratoria (e.g. New York, 50MW+) - Limit is that it is unsuitable to large training clusters and there is a backlash risk	Avoids thresholds	6-12 mo	Low
12	**Legal and institutional responses**	- Litigation; push for federal standards; industry pledges - Limit is uncertainty about outcomes	Clearer rules over time	6-24 mo	Low

Source: Epoch AI, Ballotpedia, Datacenter Dynamics, AP, Nomura estimates

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Fig. 2: Hynix (000660 KS, Buy) – 2028F earnings/valuation by memory price scenario

Assuming the share price remains at the current level of KRW1,300,000

Memory price scenario	Current assumption	-10%	-20%	-30%	-40%	-50%
Assumptions						
ASP (USD/GB)						
DRAM	19.6	17.6	15.7	13.7	11.8	9.8
NAND	0.32	0.29	0.26	0.23	0.19	0.16
Cost (USD/GB)						
DRAM	3.6	3.6	3.6	3.6	3.6	3.6
NAND	0.08	0.08	0.08	0.08	0.08	0.08
Shipment (bn GB)						
DRAM	23	23	23	23	23	23
NAND	385	385	385	385	385	385
Earnings (KRWtn)						
Revenue	759	683	608	532	456	380
OP	606	531	455	380	304	228
NP	486	426	365	305	244	184
BV	830	799	772	746	719	688
Shareholder return (KRWtn)						
Dividend	40	35	26	17	8	3
Buyback	200	175	150	125	100	75
Share count (mn shares)						
Buyback	154	135	115	96	77	58
End-2028	**487**	**506**	**525**	**544**	**564**	**583**
Per share (KRW)						
EPS (avg)	861,674	743,193	626,935	514,437	405,519	300,012
EPS (end)	928,825	842,032	695,837	559,933	433,269	314,935
BVPS (end)	1,759,590	1,579,397	1,470,279	1,370,932	1,275,504	1,181,102
Valuation						
P/E (year-avg)	**1.5 x**	**1.7 x**	**2.1 x**	**2.5 x**	**3.2 x**	**4.3 x**
P/E (year-end)	**1.4 x**	**1.5 x**	**1.9 x**	**2.3 x**	**3.0 x**	**4.1 x**
P/B (year-end)	**0.7 x**	**0.8 x**	**0.9 x**	**0.9 x**	**1.0 x**	**1.1 x**

Note: "Current assumption" stands for our up-to-date 2028F earnings estimates and involved assumptions
Source: Nomura estimates

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Appendix A-1

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Issuer	Ticker	Price	Price date	Stock rating	Sector rating	Disclosures
SK Hynix	000660 KS	KRW 1,396,000	04-Nov-2026	Buy	N/A	A4,A5,A6,A7

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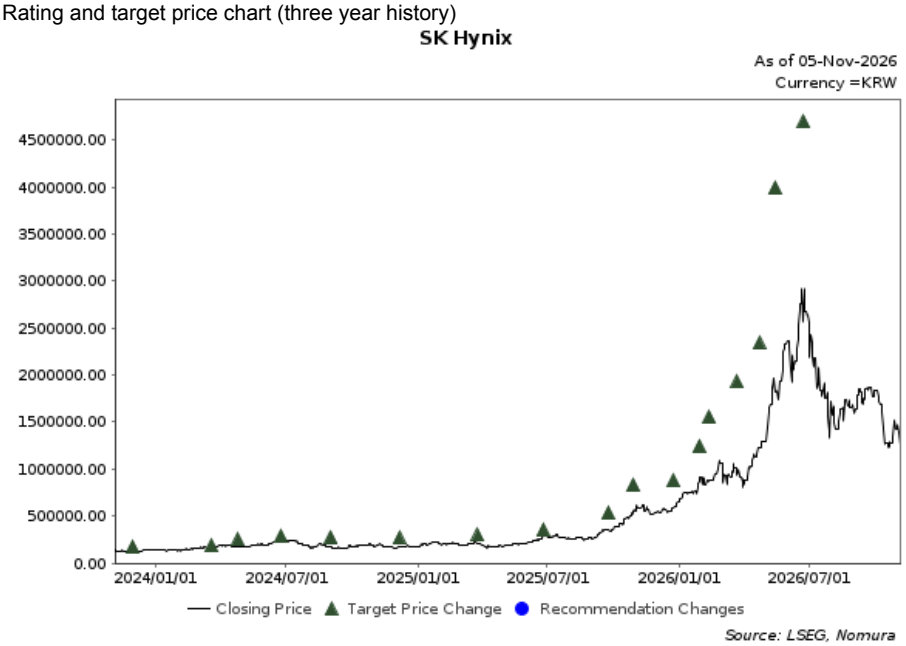
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SK Hynix (000660 KS) **KRW 1,396,000 (04-Nov-2026)** Buy (Sector rating: N/A)

Rating and target price chart (three year history)



Date	Rating	Target price	Closing price
24-Jun-26		4,700,000.00	2,580,000.00
15-May-26		4,000,000.00	1,819,000.00
23-Apr-26		2,340,000.00	1,225,000.00
23-Mar-26		1,930,000.00	933,000.00
12-Feb-26		1,560,000.00	888,000.00
29-Jan-26		1,250,000.00	861,000.00
24-Dec-25		880,000.00	588,000.00
29-Oct-25		840,000.00	558,000.00
24-Sep-25		540,000.00	357,500.00
25-Jun-25		360,000.00	286,000.00
26-Mar-25		300,000.00	214,000.00
06-Dec-24		270,000.00	167,100.00
02-Sep-24		280,000.00	174,000.00
24-Jun-24		290,000.00	223,000.00
25-Apr-24		250,000.00	170,600.00
19-Mar-24		190,000.00	160,200.00
30-Nov-23		180,000.00	133,900.00

For explanation of ratings refer to the stock rating keys located after chart(s)

Valuation Methodology Our 12-month target price of KRW4,700,000 is derived by applying a target P/B of 4.8x to 12MF BVPS of KRW973,288. Benchmark for the stock is KOSPI 200.
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